



SCHUMANN'S STUDIO

In 1852, Schumann moved to Düsseldorf; the studio in his house is shown here. The move initially sparked creativity in him, but by 1853 he was suffering mental instability and the next year attempted suicide by hurling himself into the Rhine.

A tragic finale

In September of that year, the unknown 20-year-old composer Johannes Brahms turned up at the Schumanns' door. Immediately adopted as a family friend and hailed by Schumann in print as a genius of the future, Brahms was a witness to the tragic finale to Schumann's life. Plagued by hallucinations, on February 27, 1854, Schumann fled his home and threw himself into the Rhine. He was rescued and taken at his own request to an asylum for the insane at Endenich, near Bonn. There he descended into terminal mental and physical decline.

Numerous theories have been proposed concerning Schumann's condition, including that he was suffering the long-term effects of poisoning by mercury, administered as a cure for syphilis. What is